

The illustration is a stylized, monochromatic scene in shades of blue and black. In the upper left, a figure in a long, dark, patterned dress stands before a dark, pointed structure. To their right, another figure in a blue and black dress stands before a similar structure. In the upper right, a row of lit candles sits on a dark surface. In the lower left, a profile of a woman with long, wavy hair is visible. The background features dark, pointed shapes and a light blue area with a small, dark, stepped structure. The overall mood is somber and mysterious.

*Hermod found Baldr and Hel sitting in a vast hall in Niflheim, the land of the dead.*

Hel thought for a moment. “I want you to prove that Baldr is as loved as you say. I will only set him free if all things in the cosmos – both living and non-living – weep for him.” She then held up a bony finger. “But if even a single thing refuses to cry, he’ll remain at my side in Niflheim.”

When Hermod returned and told the Aesir what Hel had said, Odin and Frigg sent out messengers all over the cosmos to ask every living and non-living thing to weep for Baldr. And so they did: people, animals, stars, birds, flowers, stones – even metals beaded with water as if frost had melted to dew.

But a giantess turned the messengers away. “Baldr gave me no joy,” she said, “so let Hel keep him.” Some believed that the giantess was really Loki in disguise, who in his malice had doomed Baldr for a second time.